frequently to allude' to this fact, he was not punished for his refusal in any way except by such, possibly tart, remarks. Indeed, Badauni writes that while 'shameless and ill-starred wretches' instigated Akbar to do more to popularize his cult, Akbar replied that 'confidence in him as a leader was a matter of time, and good counsel, and did not require the sword'. He would not compel devotion, nor would he bribe it, even if Badauni believed that had Akbar only 'spent a little money', he'd have caught many more disciples in 'his devilish nets'.

It wasn't only Badauni who refused to be thus entangled. Raja Todar Mal remained devoted to his idols until the end of his days – once, having lost them on a march, he stopped eating – which may account for why Abul Fazl often balances praise for the warrior-accountant with disappointed comments on his 'bigotry'. Akbar, too, may have made the kind of allusions Badauni complains about to Todar Mal's recalcitrance: the emperor's grandson, Shahjahan, remembered how Akbar 'complained of the raja's independence, vanity, and bigoted adherence to Hinduism'.[52] Bhagwant Das and Man Singh, too, are said to have declined Akbar's invitation, though somewhat less dramatically than Qutubuddin or Shahbaz, with Man Singh declaring that he would convert from Hinduism to Islam on the emperor's command, but knew of no religion other than these two.[53]

Amir Fathullah Shirazi, for whom Akbar had such fond respect, would not entertain his new faith, so much so that even Badauni, though decrying Fathullah as a 'worldly office-hunter, and . . . worshipper of mammon' acknowledges his 'bluff honesty'. Akbar was keen, according to Badauni, to have Fathullah join him in his critical examination of Islam. Once, the emperor tried to tempt the mechanically talented amir to participate in a debate on various scientifically impossible miracles attributed to the Prophet Muhammad, glancing at him every so often 'because he wanted him to say something', but Fathullah did not oblige: he 'looked straight ahead of himself, and did not utter a syllable'. Indeed, far from joining Akbar, either in his irreverence or his new religion, Fathullah, a 'staunch Shiah', would offer his own prayers in court, 'with the greatest composure . . . a thing which no one else would have dared to do'.[54]

But was it a religion at all that Akbar was propounding?

'Since the early nineteenth century,' writes J.F. Richards, 'generations of